

# Gender Programming – beyond tokenism

## Sheeba Thomas



**Sheeba Thomas**  
CEO, Vedatma Consulting

It's been an enriching and fascinating 27 years filled with challenges, learning, and enormous success, recalls Sheeba, from being a young novice lawyer finding her footing in top multinationals in the Service Industry to an enabling, strategic, and transformational leader in the Education sector.

A Symbiosis Pune, Law and Business Management alumna, Sheeba spent her formative years in the service industry working for Sterling Holiday Resorts, Quality Inn Hotels and Sodexo Pass. What paved her way into the education sector was a brief entrepreneurial challenge, with Giraffe Learning, of starting a greenfield unit from the ground up. Subsequently, as Vice President with Evolv Services and NIIT she has earmarked a phenomenal 16 years in the industry. In the recent years as CEO of CKC, leading the transformational efforts, and now as CEO of Vedatma Consulting, she is best known as a leader for her zeal for

Operations & People Management, while 'simultaneously' driving the business's P&L demands.

Despite her success in the Corporate Sector, this CEO shares, that statistically while women heading firms reached an all-time high of 41 in 2021 at the Fortune 500, up from 6.6 percent in 2019 to 8.2 percent in 2021, their representation is still under 10%. As a progressive advocate for gender quotas in the legislative realm, she proclaims not being an outspoken supporter of 'Gender Programming' in the 'business' realm – a concept she feels that has yielded only minor gains in terms of closing the gender gap in the workplace.

She goes on to quote that, in the 1970s, gender parity became a Scandinavian novelty; and much before corporations, political parties had included voluntary quota targets to increase female recruitment. While the gender quota narrative shifted from the 'developed west' to the 'developing others', it's worth noting that the primary focus was and continues to be on increasing the number of women at the top, rather than in the middle. The driving motivator – Inspire to Aspire. Is this however not dooming if there are actually no women to promote?

The drop-off point for women mostly is in their mid-career years. To assist aspiring women wade through the difficulties they confront during this stage, companies, in place of penalising career interruptions must encourage equal compensation structures and provide suitable

incentives for them to be able to access support.

Mentorship programs are an effective cure towards the development of a strengthened female pipeline at all levels and across disciplines beyond the typical feminine branded positions of HR and Communications. More women should be able to take on roles that involve metal and money, and thereon rise to positions of power when they are 'ready'.

***"Quota = Reservation, and therefore ZERO merit, is that not the unequivocal perception?"*** "I would like to sit at the table because I have earned it, not because I am the result of a quota. Quotas, in my opinion, may cause women to either rise to positions of authority before they are ready, or be used to help less talented women gain jobs, both being potentially retrograde trends. We should instead consider raising the bar and make it more difficult for less capable men to get those coveted jobs. Would we, as women, not prefer to take on an 'equal' role collaborating with people of all genders rather than representing charges of tokenism?"

***"Women held up half the sky,"*** Mao Zedong famously declared.

I proudly stand on the shoulders of other female leaders who paved the way for me, and I will gladly contribute my own for the next generation

***"Women must learn to play the game as men do,"*** those words from Eleanor Roosevelt will continue to echo in my mind, said Sheeba, as her parting remark!